John von Neumann, like Einstein, had made it out of Germany early. He and his friend and fellow Hungarian Eugene Wigner were both offered positions at Princeton in 1930. Knowing that the two men were unlikely to simply pack up and leave Europe, Princeton offered them half-time appointments: visit Princeton for half the year, and then go back to their jobs at the University of Berlin, where they could lounge in coffee shops with Einstein and Schrödinger, for the other half. Both men accepted the generous offer, but they had different opinions of the New World. Von Neumann immediately took to the States, holding dinner parties with his wife almost nightly, always in impeccable attire (von Neumann once rode a mule into the Grand Canyon while wearing a three-piece pinstriped suit). Wigner was more reluctant to leave Europe behind. Yet it was clear to him that he wouldn't be able to return to Berlin indefinitely. "There was no question in the mind of any person that the days of foreigners [in Germany], particularly with Jewish ancestry, were numbered," Wigner recalled. "It was so obvious that you didn't have to be perceptive.… It's like, 'Well, it will be colder in December.' Yes, it will be. We know it will." When Hitler came to power, Wigner and von Neumann simply didn't return to Berlin—both men had been fired from their German posts, being of Jewish descent.

Von Neumann and Wigner were two of a brilliantly gifted group of Hungarian Jewish scientists of their generation. Their astounding mathematical abilities and diverse scientific talents led their colleagues to jokingly suggest that Hungary was merely a cover story obscuring their true origin. "These people were really visitors from Mars," said their colleague Otto Frisch. "For them… it was difficult to speak without an accent that would give them away and therefore they chose to pretend to be Hungarians whose inability to speak any language without accent is well known; except Hungarian, and [these] brilliant men all lived elsewhere." Von Neumann in particular seemed almost inhuman in his brilliance. His colleagues at Princeton said that he "was indeed a demigod, but he had made a thorough, detailed study of human beings and could imitate them perfectly." Von Neumann and the Martians did often think about things differently from their colleagues—including the foundations of quantum physics.

Not long after he started visiting Princeton, von Neumann completed a textbook on quantum physics that became an instant classic. Other